

UPSTRIDE RESOURCES

FREE PRACTICAL DIGITAL GROWTH SERIES

Email Automation Playbook

Deliver timely, relevant communication across the customer journey.

A lifecycle guide for permission, segmentation, automation, deliverability, and continuous optimization.

STRATEGY > SYSTEM > SCALE

YOUR NEXT STEP FORWARD

How to use this playbook

A lifecycle guide for permission, segmentation, automation, deliverability, and continuous optimization.

**READ**

Understand the operating model.

**ASSESS**

Score your current state honestly.

**BUILD**

Complete one focused pilot.

**REVIEW**

Use evidence to improve the system.

A note on responsible use

This free publication is for educational and planning purposes. Adapt every recommendation to your business, customers, contracts, privacy obligations, security requirements, and local laws. It is not legal, financial, accounting, cybersecurity, or regulatory advice. Product and platform capabilities change; verify current requirements before implementation.



BASELINE

Where are you now?

Rate each statement from 1 (not true yet) to 5 (consistently true). Use the lowest scores to choose your first improvement.

01 We have a shared definition of success for permission.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

02 The current workflow and ownership are documented and understood.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

03 Our tools and data have clear sources of truth.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

04 Important exceptions are identified and assigned to a person.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

05 We measure outcomes, quality, and adoption - not only activity.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

06 The team reviews and improves the system on a regular cadence.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

YOUR BASELINE SCORE

6-14 START | 15-23 STABILIZE | 24-30 SCALE



THE UPSTRIDE FRAMEWORK

Five moves that build momentum

Use this sequence to move from a scattered effort to a visible, repeatable system.

01

PERMISSION

Set the direction and desired outcome.

02

SEGMENT

Remove ambiguity and unnecessary friction.

03

TRIGGER

Create the core workflow and supporting assets.

04

SERVE

Launch with ownership, controls, and visibility.

05

OPTIMIZE

Learn from evidence and strengthen the system.



PERMISSION IN PRACTICE

Earn permission

A healthy email program begins with clear consent, expectations, and a valuable reason to subscribe.

OPERATING PRINCIPLE

Make the next right action obvious, owned, and measurable.

Three actions to take

1

Explain what subscribers will receive

Explain what subscribers will receive.

2

Record consent and source accurately

Record consent and source accurately.

3

Make preferences and unsubscribe easy

Make preferences and unsubscribe easy.

DECISION PROMPT

What would become easier for the customer or the team if this part of the system worked reliably every time?

SEGMENT IN PRACTICE

Build useful segments

Lifecycle stage and behavior often predict relevance better than broad demographics.

OPERATING PRINCIPLE

Make the next right action obvious, owned, and measurable.

Three actions to take

1

Start with a small set of actionable segments

Start with a small set of actionable segments.

2

Define entry and exit rules

Define entry and exit rules.

3

Avoid collecting data without a use case

Avoid collecting data without a use case.

DECISION PROMPT

What would become easier for the customer or the team if this part of the system worked reliably every time?

TRIGGER IN PRACTICE

Design triggered journeys

Automations should respond to meaningful events and stop when the goal is achieved.

OPERATING PRINCIPLE

Make the next right action obvious, owned, and measurable.

Three actions to take

1

Map welcome, nurture, purchase, and re-engagement

Map welcome, nurture, purchase, and re-engagement.

2

Set delays based on customer context

Set delays based on customer context.

3

Prevent overlapping or contradictory messages

Prevent overlapping or contradictory messages.

DECISION PROMPT

What would become easier for the customer or the team if this part of the system worked reliably every time?

SERVE IN PRACTICE

Protect deliverability

Reputation depends on permission, engagement, authentication, and list hygiene.

OPERATING PRINCIPLE

Make the next right action obvious, owned, and measurable.

Three actions to take

1

Configure sending-domain authentication

Configure sending-domain authentication.

2

Remove persistent invalid addresses

Remove persistent invalid addresses.

3

Monitor complaints and unusual volume changes

Monitor complaints and unusual volume changes.

DECISION PROMPT

What would become easier for the customer or the team if this part of the system worked reliably every time?

OPTIMIZE IN PRACTICE

Optimize for customer value

Improve the entire journey rather than chasing isolated open rates.

OPERATING PRINCIPLE

Make the next right action obvious, owned, and measurable.

Three actions to take

1

Test one meaningful hypothesis at a time

Test one meaningful hypothesis at a time.

2

Measure clicks, replies, conversion, and retention

Measure clicks, replies, conversion, and retention.

3

Review content for usefulness and clarity

Review content for usefulness and clarity.

DECISION PROMPT

What would become easier for the customer or the team if this part of the system worked reliably every time?

MOVE FROM IDEA TO PILOT

A focused implementation sprint

Keep the first implementation narrow enough to learn quickly and important enough to matter.

1

Audit consent and list sources

DAYS 1-3

2

Define lifecycle segments

DAYS 4-7

3

Map priority automations

DAYS 8-11

4

Write and design the first flow

DAYS 12-16

5

Configure tracking and safeguards

DAYS 17-21

6

Test every branch

DAYS 22-26

7

Launch and review weekly

DAYS 27-30



MAKE IT CONCRETE

One-page system brief

Complete this before selecting tools or building assets. Short, specific answers are more useful than broad ambition.

01 AUDIENCE AND PERMISSION SOURCE

02 TRIGGER EVENT

03 JOURNEY GOAL

04 SEGMENT AND EXCLUSION RULES

05 MESSAGE SEQUENCE

06 EXIT CONDITION AND KPI



EVIDENCE OVER ACTIVITY

A practical scorecard

Choose a small set of measures that show customer value, operational quality, and sustainable adoption.

MEASURE	BASELINE	TARGET	CADENCE
Delivery rate			
Click rate			
Reply rate			
Journey conversion			
Unsubscribe rate			

REVIEW QUESTION

What changed, why did it change, and what will we do next?



READY TO MOVE FORWARD?

Final readiness check

A healthy launch has clarity, ownership, safeguards, measurement, and a defined next review.

- ☐ The desired business and customer outcome is specific.
- ☐ A named owner is accountable for the system.
- ☐ The normal workflow and important exceptions are documented.
- ☐ Data access, privacy, and security requirements are reviewed.
- ☐ Users have been trained in the real workflow.
- ☐ Success measures have baselines, targets, and owners.
- ☐ A rollback or recovery path exists where needed.
- ☐ The first improvement review is scheduled.

YOUR NEXT STEP FORWARD

Continue with Email Marketing & Automation Specialist.

See the guided learning path: upstride-three.vercel.app/academy/email-marketing-automation

FREE GUIDE TO GUIDED PRACTICE

Ready to build the skill?

This playbook gives you the framework. The matching Upstride Academy program helps you apply it through structured lessons, practical projects, downloadable tools, and a capstone.

RECOMMENDED PROGRAM

Email Marketing & Automation Specialist

UPSTRIDE ACADEMY | PRACTICAL, PROJECT-BASED LEARNING

What the program helps you do

1

Map lifecycle segments and triggered journeys

Map lifecycle segments and triggered journeys through guided exercises and feedback-ready project work.

2

Build useful, permission-based email flows

Build useful, permission-based email flows through guided exercises and feedback-ready project work.

3

Create and test a complete automation sequence

Create and test a complete automation sequence through guided exercises and feedback-ready project work.

CHOOSE YOUR SUPPORT LEVEL

Basic | Pro | Mentored

Review current package details and availability on the course page before enrolling.

View the program and enroll

upstride-three.vercel.app/academy/email-marketing-automation